

AI Agent Opportunities in HR Operations and Shared Services

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Initiatives: Technologies and Markets; Transform HR through AI

HR operations and HR shared services teams face mounting efficiency and employee experience expectations. CHROs can use this research to pinpoint where AI agents solve HR ops challenges — like high volumes, administrative burden, and inconsistent service — to elevate impact across the organization.

Insights at a Glance

AI agents are becoming a critical lever for HR operations (inclusive of HR shared services), as pressure mounts to improve cost efficiency, service quality, and the employee experience. Unlike conventional automation, AI agents deliver instant, personalized support, automate routine work, and learn from interactions — boosting productivity, reducing administrative burden, and surfacing emerging trends and risks. For CHROs, deploying AI agents in HR operations is increasingly strategic. When effectively implemented, they shift HR teams away from transactional work and toward service innovation, compliance, and more-personalized employee support, driving greater organizational value.

CHROs will realize the greatest value of agentic AI for HR operations by concentrating investment on high-fit, high-impact use cases aligned to core operational strategic outcomes. This disciplined approach is essential to transforming HR operations and delivering a more efficient and employee-centric HR service model.

The effectiveness of AI agents varies based on task complexity, risk, and the need for contextual understanding:

- **High agentic AI fit:** Dynamic, high-volume interactions where context, judgment, and personalization matter and the cost of error is manageable.

Examples include personalized employee inquiries, real-time transactional support, and case triage/routing.

- **Medium agentic AI fit:** Processes already well-serviced by rule-based automation, where AI agents add value primarily as a conversational or orchestration layer.

Examples include document generation and onboarding orchestration.

- **Low agentic AI fit:** Highly sensitive, complex, or high-risk scenarios that require human oversight, escalation, and accountability.

Examples include complex case management and compliance/risk detection.

AI agent use cases map to core HR operations strategic outcomes — e.g., elevated employee experience, improved operational efficiency, scalable service delivery, greater focus on higher-value work, and improved decision making — ensuring technology investments translate into measurable operational and strategic gains. For example, when the primary goal is to elevate the employee experience, high-value capabilities include FAQ and knowledge retrieval, personal information inquiries, transactional self-service, and policy navigation and guidance.

Strategic Planning Assumption

By 2028, at least 75% of HR operations functions will have launched AI agent initiatives, yet 50% will fall short of intended outcomes due to weak data and technology foundations, limited process reengineering, and inadequate change management.

Issue Context

HR operations, inclusive of HR shared services, faces mounting pressure to deliver greater efficiency and a superior employee experience. Organizations now expect HR to surpass traditional service models by reducing costs and providing more personalized, responsive support. However, reliance on manual processes and fragmented systems leads to slow response times, operational delays, and friction for both employees and HR teams. CHROs are looking to modernize HR operations to reduce costs and improve service quality by augmenting existing systems with AI. Sixty-three percent of CHROs augmenting preexisting systems with AI expect cost or time savings, and 44% expect a positive impact on employee experience and engagement. ¹

Impact Brief

Deploying AI agents in HR operations enables the automation of routine work while delivering personalized, context-aware support and proactive issue resolution. Unlike traditional automation, AI agents can operate across complex, variable scenarios, allowing HR teams to divert focus away from administrative tasks to higher-value work. This approach streamlines operations, increases efficiency, and enhances the employee experience. Over time, these capabilities support greater strategic value through service innovation, continuous improvement, and expert handling of complex or sensitive employee matters. For further context on HR AI agents, see [AI Agent Essentials for CHROs](#).

More Detail

Top HR Operations Agentic AI Opportunities

As HR functions explore the adoption of agentic AI, it's essential to pinpoint which HR operations tasks offer the greatest potential for transformation. The most significant gains come in areas requiring adaptability and contextual understanding — such as personalized employee queries, transactional self-service, and case triage — because these tasks involve complex decision making, nuanced responses, and the ability to learn from interactions. In contrast, tasks like payroll processing or data entry follow fixed rules and are already efficiently handled by traditional automation, so additional AI intervention offers limited incremental value. See [Getting Started With AI Agents in HR](#) for further guidance.

To prioritize investment and ensure successful adoption of AI agents in HR operations, CHROs must understand which processes are best suited for agentic AI, considering their complexity and the potential for automation or augmentation. Figure 1 illustrates where agentic AI offers the greatest opportunity and which tasks are a best fit compared to other types of AI or automation:

- **High agentic AI fit:** Medium-complexity tasks where the environment is too dynamic for rigid automation, yet the cost of error is low enough to manage risk.
- **Medium agentic AI fit:** Scenarios where traditional automation and task orchestration are already effective, but an AI agent can add value as a conversational front end.
- **Low agentic AI fit:** Highly complicated, sensitive, or high-risk scenarios, where human expertise and judgment remain essential.

Figure 1: Agentic AI Opportunities and Fit in HR Operations/HR Shared Services

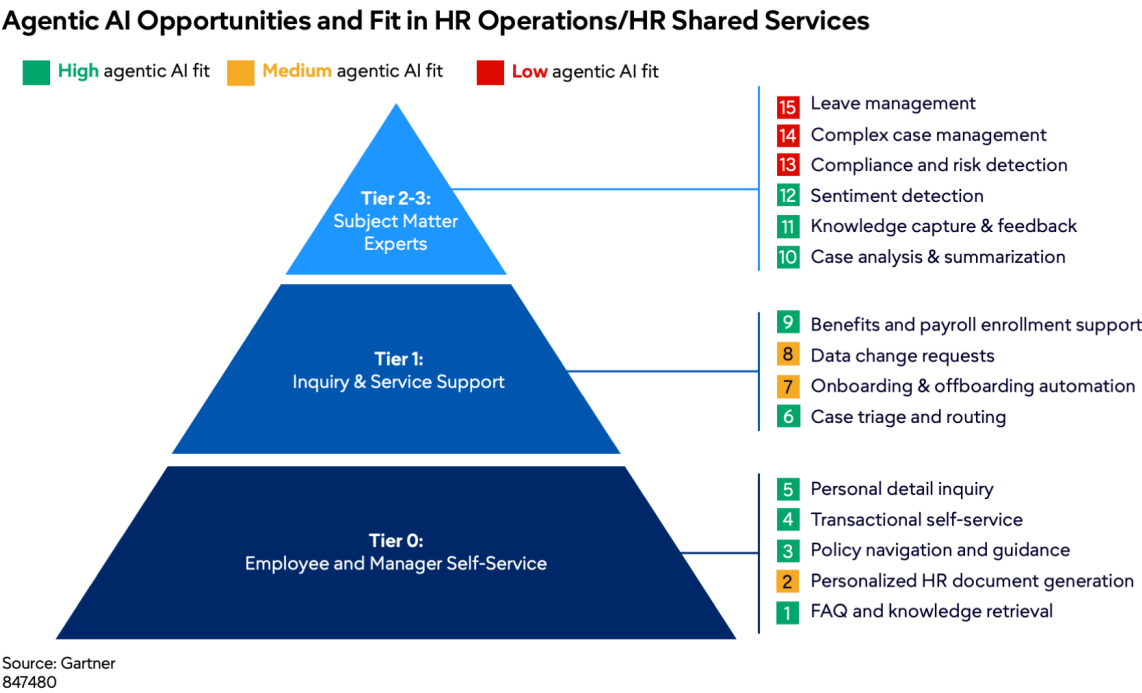


Table 1 provides additional detail on each HR operations opportunity.

Table 1: Key HR Operations Tasks Agentic AI Fit and Capabilities

(Enlarged table in Appendix)

	Task/Process	Agentic AI fit	Potential agentic AI capabilities
Tier 0	1 – FAQ and knowledge retrieval	High	Instant 24/7, tailored responses to common HR questions based on each employee's profile, reducing wait times and freeing up HR staff.
Tier 0	2 – Personalized HR document generation	Medium	Conversational front-end to securely autogenerate and deliver personalized documents (e.g., employee verification or payslip).
Tier 0	3 – Policy navigation and guidance	High	Personalize guidance to relevant policies and explanation of key points in plain language.
Tier 0	4 – Transactional self-service	High	Collect details from employees for routine HR tasks (address changes, direct deposit, time-off requests) via conversational user interface, validate the data, and update systems in real time.
Tier 0	5 – Personal detail inquiry	High	Instantly retrieve and present personalized information, such as time off balances or pay details.
Tier 1	6 – Case triage and routing	High	Analyze inquiries and route assignment to the right team member.
Tier 1	7 – Onboarding and offboarding automation	Medium	Orchestrate tasks, reminders, and completion tracking for new hires, internal mobility, or exiting employees.
Tier 1	8 – Data change requests	Medium	Collect, validate, and process employee data changes.
Tier 1	9 – Benefits and payroll enrollment support	High	Personalize recommendations and guidance for selecting and updating enrollments.
Tier 2-3	10 – Case analysis and summarization	High	Analyze case history, extracting key insights and summary report.
Tier 2-3	11 – Knowledge capture and feedback	High	Capture lessons, update knowledge base, and surface trends for process improvement.
Tier 2-3	12 – Sentiment detection	High	Proactively identify scenarios of dissatisfaction to leverage in service evolution. May offer draft action and communication plans.
Tier 2-3	13 – Compliance and risk detection	Low	Monitor and flag cases or agent responses with potential compliance violations and guidance on resolution.
Tier 2-3	14 – Complex case management	Low	Assist with tracking, compliance monitoring, and recommendations.
Tier 2-3	15 – Leave management	Low	Automate leaving processing, including documentation processing, possibly identifying conflicts.

Source: Gartner (March 2026)

Ultimately, aligning AI agents to the right tasks is crucial for driving operational transformation and elevating the employee experience.

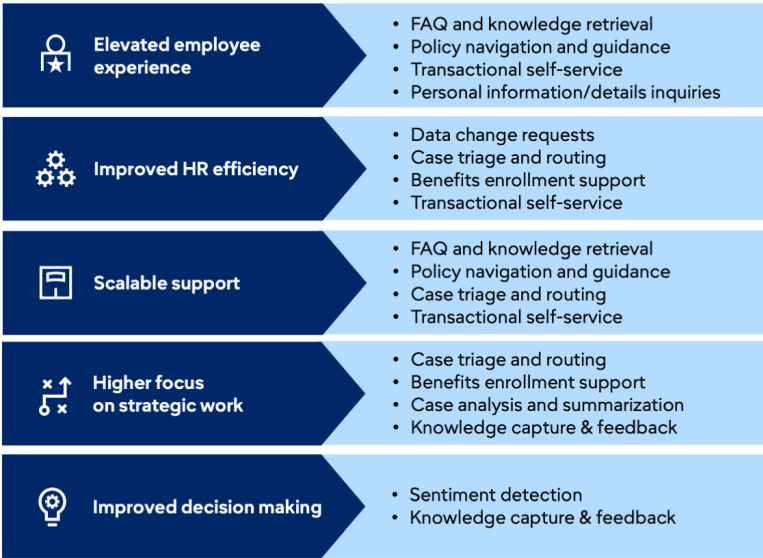
High-Value Strategic Outcomes Achieved Through Agentic AI

Establishing a clear vision of key outcomes and goals lays the groundwork for identifying where agentic AI can make the greatest impact within HR operations. With these priorities, CHROs can focus investments on the opportunities and use cases that will deliver the most value.

Figure 2 shows the highest-impact agentic AI use cases in HR and the strategic outcomes they enable. Table 2 elaborates on the specific ways AI agents contribute to achieving these goals. Use this framework to identify the highest-impact agentic AI use cases, prioritize investments that are aligned with strategic goals, and guide the evolution toward a more advanced HR operations function.

Figure 2: Targeted Agentic AI Use Cases by HR Operations Strategic Outcome

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Source: Gartner 847480

Table 2: Top Strategic Outcomes Agentic AI Helps Achieve in HR Operations
(Enlarged table in Appendix)

Strategic outcome	How agentic AI supports	How to prioritize	Top use cases
Elevated employee experience	■ Deliver 24/7 personalized support. ■ Resolve inquiries faster. ■ Reduce administrative burden.	Prioritize addressing high-volume, routine employee interactions that generate friction and frequent administrative tasks.	■ FAQ and knowledge retrieval ■ Policy navigation and guidance ■ Transactional self-service ■ Personal detail inquiry
Improved HR efficiency	■ Automate repetitive administrative tasks. ■ Streamline workflows. ■ Reduce manual effort and errors. ■ Improve data quality through automated validation.	Target manual, repetitive processes that consume HR resources and create bottlenecks.	■ Data change requests ■ Case triage and routing ■ Benefits enrollment support ■ Transactional self-service
Scalable support	■ Provide consistent service at any volume. ■ Handle peaks in demand without extra headcount. ■ Support organizational growth and change. ■ Boost productivity with existing resources.	Focus on tasks that require consistent, 24/7 coverage or support across locations/languages.	■ FAQ and knowledge retrieval ■ Policy navigation and guidance ■ Case triage and routing ■ Transactional self-service
Greater focus on strategic work	■ Free HR resources to focus on service improvement. ■ Redirect HR expertise toward handling more complex or sensitive cases. ■ Shift from reactive case management to proactive design. ■ Enable a deeper analysis of recurring issues.	Identify areas where automation can free HR staff for higher-value, complex work.	■ Data change requests ■ Case triage and routing ■ Benefits and payroll enrollment support ■ Transactional self-service
Improved decision making	■ Surface real-time service trends. ■ Identify root causes behind common issues. ■ Reveal policy gaps based on inquiry patterns. ■ Enable evidence-based decisions for continuous improvement.	Choose where to enable data-driven insights and proactive interventions in HR processes.	■ Sentiment detection ■ Knowledge capture and feedback

Source: Gartner (March 2025)

Evidence

¹ 2025 Gartner Q4 AI and HR Function CHRO Survey. This survey was conducted to gain insights into CHRO perspectives on the current state of AI within their organizations and HR functions, as well as to collect up-to-date information on HR functional transformation. The research was conducted online from 17 November to 16 December, 2025, and contains responses from 110 heads of HR with representation from various geographies, industries, and functions. Disclaimer: The results of this survey do not represent global findings or the market as a whole, but reflect the sentiments of the respondents and companies surveyed.

Recommended by the Authors

Some documents may not be available as part of your current Gartner subscription.

[Understand the Impact of AI Across HR Processes to Accelerate HR Transformation](#)

[The Impact of AI on the HR Operating Model](#)

[Elevate HR Processes With AI Agentic Workflows](#)

[Address 5 Gaps to Unlock HR AI Agent Success](#)

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